



Hi,

This website, Athy's Kitchen Diary, was created as a demonstration project to perform a comprehensive Technical SEO Audit.

The site intentionally contains several technical and on-page SEO issues such as indexing problems, missing metadata, image optimization gaps, URL structure issues, and other common SEO errors. These issues were deliberately left unresolved so they could be identified, analyzed, and documented as part of the audit process.

The purpose of this project is to demonstrate my ability to:

- Conduct a full technical SEO audit
- Identify critical SEO issues affecting website performance
- Provide practical recommendations and solutions
- Use professional SEO tools and methodologies

This project simulates a real-world SEO audit scenario where a website contains multiple optimization opportunities. The findings and recommendations presented in this report illustrate how these issues can be diagnosed and improved to enhance search engine visibility and user experience.

Thank you.



Athy's Kitchen Diary
Where recipes meet memories

TECHNICAL SEO AUDIT REPORT

Audited Website	Athy's Kitchen Diary
URL	athyskitchendiary.wordpress.com
Audit Type	Technical SEO Audit
Prepared For	Client Delivery
Prepared By	Athiramol PS
Date	April 2026

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1. Project Overview

This report presents the findings and recommendations of a comprehensive technical SEO audit conducted for Athy's Kitchen Diary, a WordPress-hosted food and recipe blog centred on authentic Kerala home cooking content. The primary objective was to assess the website's technical SEO health, identify structural issues affecting search visibility, and provide actionable recommendations to improve crawlability, indexation, user experience, and organic performance.

The audit examined all core technical SEO pillars, including crawlability, indexability, site architecture, metadata quality, page performance, mobile usability, and content discoverability. As a WordPress.com-hosted blog, the site benefits from platform-level stability; however, it is also subject to CMS-level technical constraints that must be factored into the implementation of all recommendations.

The audit combined structured quantitative tooling with thorough manual review, ensuring both automated detection and human validation of all findings.

2. SEO Goals

The audit was conducted to support the following business and search performance objectives:

- Ensure search engines can properly crawl the website.
- Ensure important pages are being indexed correctly.
- Identify and fix blocked pages, including robots.txt and noindex issues.
- Improve website speed and performance in line with Google's Core Web Vitals standards.
- Fix broken links, 404 errors, and redirect issues.
- Improve website structure and internal linking.
- Optimise URL structure for clarity and SEO-friendliness.
- Ensure mobile-friendliness and responsive design across all devices.
- Verify HTTPS security and its correct implementation.
- Detect duplicate content and canonical tag issues.
- Validate structured data and schema markup.
- Improve overall user experience from a technical standpoint.
- Help search engines better understand the website's content and context.
- Improve ranking potential by removing technical barriers to visibility.

3. Audit Methodology & Tools Used

The audit combined structured quantitative tooling with thorough manual review, ensuring both automated detection and human validation of all findings.

Automated Site Crawl

Screaming Frog SEO Spider was used to extract site structure, title tags, meta descriptions, image alt attributes, and to surface technical issues at scale.

Performance & Mobile Testing

Google PageSpeed Insights and Google's Mobile-Friendly Test were used to measure Core Web Vitals (LCP, FCP, CLS) across both desktop and mobile experiences.

Manual Browser Inspection

Page-level review of navigation structure, heading hierarchy, content relevance, image loading behaviour, and JavaScript rendering.

Structured Data Testing

Google's Rich Results Test was used to detect the presence or absence of valid schema markup on key recipe pages.

Backlink & Ranking Review

Preliminary external link profile and keyword visibility checks conducted via Semrush.

Tools Used

- Google Search Console
- Google PageSpeed Insights
- Screaming Frog SEO Spider
- Google Rich Results Test
- Semrush (backlink and ranking analysis)
- Google Analytics (setup review)
- Manual source code inspection
- WordPress Admin dashboard review

These tools align with standard consultancy-level WordPress SEO audit processes.

4. Key Findings

4.1 Preliminary Questions

Positive Findings

- No recent platform migration has taken place, eliminating the risk of migration-related ranking volatility.
- The client has admin-level access to the WordPress dashboard, enabling implementation of all technical recommendations.
- Google Search Console is connected, verified, and actively reporting data — a strong foundation for ongoing monitoring.

Issues Identified

- DNS access is not available to the client. Any domain-level changes (e.g. custom domain migration, redirect configuration) will require coordination with the hosting provider.
- Google Tag Manager is not installed. Without GTM, tracking scripts cannot be managed efficiently, and implementing conversion tracking or enhanced analytics events requires direct code access.
- Google Analytics is not connected. There is no GA4 property set up, meaning traffic, user behaviour, and conversion data are not currently being captured.
- GTM implementation is restricted on the current WordPress.com free plan, requiring a plan upgrade before it can be deployed.

4.2 Crawling

Positive Findings

- A valid robots.txt file is in place using standard WordPress defaults, and no essential pages (recipes, categories) are blocked.
- Paginated pages, JavaScript files, and parametrised URLs are all accessible to crawlers — no unnecessary restrictions detected.
- No host-level problems have been reported in Google Search Console crawl statistics over the past 90 days.
- An XML sitemap is present and correctly referenced in robots.txt, submitted to Google Search Console, and dynamically maintained with 55 URLs.
- HTML files have been crawled within the last 72 hours, confirming Googlebot is actively visiting the site.
- Internal search URLs are correctly excluded from crawling, preventing thin or duplicate content from entering the index.

Issues Identified

- Crawl activity is low and limited overall. Google Search Console data shows Googlebot is not crawling with high frequency, which is directly correlated to the site's small content volume.
- Discovery crawls account for only 2% of all crawl activity, with 98% being refresh crawls. This indicates Google is largely revisiting existing pages rather than discovering new content, which will limit growth in indexed pages.

4.3 Rendering

Positive Findings

- No 'Submitted URL seems to be a soft 404' errors are trending in Google Search Console index coverage.
- The site uses the Twenty Twenty-One WordPress theme — a responsive, block-based theme with no known rendering issues.
- No page builder is in use, which reduces DOM complexity and contributes positively to performance.
- Primary navigation and all body content remain accessible when JavaScript is disabled, confirming strong crawlability and accessibility.

Issues Identified

- Lazy loading is currently applied to above-the-fold images. This is a notable rendering issue: images that appear within the initial viewport should not be lazy loaded, as doing so artificially delays the Largest Contentful Paint (LCP) — a direct Core Web Vitals ranking signal.

4.4 Indexing

Positive Findings

- The site ranks in first position for its brand name, confirming Google has correctly identified and indexed the domain.
- HTTPS is correctly enforced, and both www and non-www versions are properly canonicalised with consistent trailing slash behaviour.
- No 301 or 404 URLs exist in the sitemap, and no redirect chains were detected.
- Canonical tags are correctly implemented across all pages.
- Search Console impressions are trending upward, indicating growing organic visibility.

Issues Identified

- Only 5 of 25 indexable URLs are currently indexed on Google. This is very low and indicates that Google has not yet fully indexed the site's available content.
- Two pages are confirmed as crawled but not indexed in Search Console: the /recipes/ page and the mambazha-pulissery post. These require investigation and should be submitted for re-indexing after any content or structural improvements.
- Twelve pages have been identified as low-content (thin) pages. Pages with insufficient content depth are at risk of being excluded from the index or ranking poorly.
- Not all indexable pages have an H1 tag, which is a fundamental on-page SEO requirement for communicating page topic to search engines.
- WordPress tag archive pages are currently indexed. Low-value tag pages with little unique content can dilute crawl budget and introduce thin content issues.

4.5 Ranking

Positive Findings

- The site correctly uses canonical tags and no redirect chains are present, preventing duplicate content from undermining rankings.
- FAQPage and HowTo structured data opportunities exist on existing recipe pages, presenting a clear pathway to enhanced SERP visibility.

Issues Identified

- The majority of internal links use generic anchor text such as 'Athy's Kitchen Diary' or 'Home'. Descriptive, keyword-rich anchor text is essential for conveying page relevance to Google and improving rankings.
- Key pages have a crawl depth of more than two clicks from the homepage. Pages buried deep in the site architecture receive less crawl priority and are harder for Google to discover and rank.
- One page is confirmed as not mobile-friendly, with slow loading identified as the primary cause.
- High-traffic pages do not link to other important recipe pages, meaning link equity is not being distributed effectively across the site.
- Some internal links carry a rel=nofollow attribute, which unnecessarily restricts PageRank flow between pages.
- Date-based segments appear in both URL subfolders and slugs (e.g. /2025/05/23/), which can make content appear outdated and does not align with long-term SEO best practice.
- No rich results (ratings, cooking time, images) are present on any ranking URL. This significantly reduces click-through rate potential and SERP real estate.
- No FAQ sections exist on any recipe pages, representing a missed opportunity for FAQPage structured data implementation.

4.6 Other Technical SEO & User Experience

Positive Findings

- HTTPS is correctly implemented and HSTS (HTTP Strict Transport Security) is enabled, providing a strong security baseline.
- The active WordPress theme (Twenty Twenty-One) and WordPress core are both up to date.
- No 5XX server errors were triggered during the crawl, indicating stable server performance.
- Internal links use absolute URLs consistently, which is acceptable and maintains link equity flow.

Issues Identified

- No SEO plugin is currently installed. Without a plugin such as Yoast SEO or Rank Math, there is no efficient mechanism to manage metadata, canonical tags, structured data, or XML sitemaps at scale.
- The overall performance score is approximately 60 out of 100, which is below the recommended threshold and will affect user retention and search rankings.
- Multiple images exceed 750KB in file size, with some reaching 2.3MB. Uncompressed images of this size are a primary driver of the poor page speed scores, particularly on mobile.
- No caching or image optimisation plugins are installed. These are fundamental tools for improving page load times on WordPress sites.

4.7 Meta & Structured Data

Positive Findings

- All pages contain a title element — no missing title tags were detected.
- All title tags are unique across the site.
- Meta descriptions are present and unique per page.
- A branded favicon is in place, contributing positively to brand recognition in SERPs.

Issues Identified

- Title tags average only 20–41 characters in length, well below the recommended 50–60 character range. Short titles fail to include sufficient keyword context and reduce click-through rates by not fully utilising available SERP space.
- Meta descriptions average 41 characters — significantly shorter than the recommended 120–160 characters. Brief meta descriptions result in weak search snippets that do not effectively communicate page value to prospective visitors.
- Multiple pages have more than one H1 tag. A single, unique H1 per page is a foundational SEO requirement. Duplicate H1s create ambiguity about a page's primary topic and weaken its relevance signal.
- 41 images are missing alt text attributes. This is the most widespread on-page SEO deficiency identified in the audit, affecting keyword relevance, image search visibility, and accessibility compliance.
- No structured data markup of any kind was detected across the site. Google's Rich Results Test returned 'No items detected', confirming that all recipe pages are currently ineligible for rich snippets, recipe carousels, and other enhanced SERP features.

4.8 URL Issues

Positive Findings

- URLs are clean, concise, and easy to share. They are HTTPS-secured, include the brand name, and use keyword-relevant slugs (e.g. /puttu-kerala-rice-puttu/).

Issues Identified

- All post URLs include date-based path segments (e.g. /2025/05/23/). This adds unnecessary length, makes URLs less memorable, and can signal to Google that content is time-sensitive — reducing its long-term ranking potential.
- The site is hosted on a WordPress.com subdomain (athyskitchendiary.wordpress.com). While functional, a subdomain limits branding credibility, reduces perceived authority, and restricts technical control over domain-level configuration such as DNS, redirects, and HSTS settings.

4.9 Page Speed & Mobile Friendliness

Performance Metrics

Metric	Desktop	Mobile	Google Target
First Contentful Paint (FCP)	1.0s	5.1s	≤ 1.8s
Largest Contentful Paint (LCP)	4.5s	21.2s	≤ 2.5s
Total Blocking Time (TBT)	0ms	10ms	≤ 200ms
Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS)	0.168	0.032	≤ 0.1
Speed Index	1.6s	5.1s	≤ 3.4s
Overall Score	85 / 100	60 / 100	> 90

Issues Identified

- The mobile LCP of 21.2 seconds is critically slow — more than eight times Google's 'poor' threshold of 4 seconds, and over eight times the 'good' target of 2.5 seconds. This represents the most severe performance issue on the site.
- The desktop LCP of 4.5 seconds also exceeds Google's threshold and is classified as 'needs improvement'. The primary cause is large, uncompressed hero images loading above the fold.
- The desktop CLS score of 0.168 exceeds Google's acceptable threshold of 0.1, indicating visible layout shifts that degrade user experience and are a confirmed ranking factor.
- The mobile PageSpeed score of 60 is well below the recommended minimum of 80. Given that Google uses mobile-first indexing, poor mobile performance directly impacts search rankings.
- Large image files (up to 2.3MB) served in legacy formats (PNG/JPG) are the primary contributor to poor load times. Lazy loading applied to above-the-fold images compounds this problem by delaying the LCP element.

5. Findings Summary

Section	Issue	Impact	Recommendation	Priority
Preliminary Questions	Google Analytics not set up; GTM not installed; no DNS access	No traffic or behaviour data; limited tracking capability	Set up GA4; upgrade plan to enable GTM; request DNS access from hosting provider	High
Crawling	Very low crawl activity; only 2% discovery crawls; 98% refresh crawls	Google predominantly revisits existing pages rather than discovering new content	Publish new content consistently; improve internal linking from homepage and category pages	Medium
Rendering	Lazy loading applied to above-the-fold images	Directly delays LCP — a confirmed Google ranking signal	Remove lazy loading from hero/above-fold images; apply only to below-fold content	High
Indexing	Only 5 of 25 pages indexed; 12 thin content pages; 2 pages crawled but not indexed	Low organic footprint; reduced crawl efficiency; missed ranking opportunities	Expand content depth on thin pages; add H1 to all pages; investigate and resolve crawled-not-indexed URLs	High
Ranking	Generic internal anchor text; key pages buried >2 clicks deep; no rich results; date-based URLs	Poor authority distribution; reduced crawlability; no enhanced SERP features	Implement keyword-rich anchor text; reduce crawl depth; add Recipe/FAQ/HowTo schema; remove date segments	High
Other Technical SEO & UX	No SEO plugin installed; images up to 2.3MB; no caching plugin; performance score ~60	Metadata unmanaged at scale; slow load times; poor user experience	Install Yoast SEO or Rank Math; compress and convert images to WebP; add caching plugin	High
Meta & Structured Data	41 images missing alt text; title tags 20–41 chars; meta descriptions 41 chars avg; no schema	Weak on-page relevance signals; ineligible for rich results; poor CTR from SERPs	Add alt text to all images; rewrite titles (50–60 chars) and meta descriptions (120–160 chars); implement JSON-LD schema	High
URL Issues	Date segments in all post URLs; hosted on wordpress.com subdomain	Less memorable URLs; perceived content aging; limited technical control	Switch to post-name permalinks; migrate to a custom domain	Medium
Page Speed & Mobile	Mobile LCP 21.2s (target <=2.5s); desktop LCP 4.5s; desktop CLS 0.168; mobile score 60	Direct negative ranking signal; poor user experience; high bounce rate risk	Compress images; serve in WebP/AVIF; fix above-fold lazy loading; enable caching; defer non-critical JS/CSS	High

6. Recommendations

6.1 Metadata Optimisation

Rewrite all page title tags to 50–60 characters, ensuring each is unique and places the primary keyword first. Avoid generic boilerplate text. Expand all meta descriptions to 120–160 characters with a clear summary of the page's content and a natural call to action. These changes will improve click-through rates, strengthen keyword signals, and ensure the site fully utilises the SERP space available to it.

6.2 Image Alt Text

Add descriptive, keyword-relevant alt text to all 41 images identified as missing this attribute. Alt text should describe the image specifically — for example, 'Traditional Kerala Unniyappam (sweet banana fritters) served on a brass plate'. This is the single most widespread on-page issue and should be treated as an immediate priority.

6.3 Heading Structure

Ensure every indexable page has exactly one H1 tag representing the primary topic. Remove or reclassify any secondary H1 tags to H2 or H3. Confirm that all pages — including category and tag archives — carry a meaningful H1.

6.4 Image Optimisation & Page Speed

Compress all images and convert them to WebP or AVIF format before uploading. Resize images to their actual display dimensions rather than relying on CSS to scale them down. Critically, remove lazy loading from all images that appear above the fold. This alone is expected to produce the most significant improvement in mobile LCP scores.

6.5 Structured Data (Recipe Schema)

Implement JSON-LD Recipe schema on every recipe page. Required fields include: name, image, author, datePublished, prepTime, cookTime, recipeIngredient, recipeInstructions, and nutrition. This will make all recipe pages eligible for rich results in Google Search — including recipe carousels, star ratings, and cooking time badges — directly increasing SERP visibility and click-through rates.

6.6 Install an SEO Plugin

Upgrade to a WordPress.com plan that supports plugin installation and implement Yoast SEO or Rank Math. These plugins provide centralised control over metadata, canonical tags, XML sitemaps, and structured data, and are essential for managing SEO at scale as the site grows.

6.7 Analytics Setup

Set up Google Analytics 4 for the site as a matter of urgency. Without GA4, there is no data available on traffic sources, user behaviour, session duration, or conversion events. Once a custom domain is in place, ensure GA4 is configured for that domain. Implement Google Tag Manager to manage all tracking scripts centrally and efficiently.

6.8 Internal Linking Strategy

Add a minimum of two contextual internal links per recipe page, using descriptive, keyword-rich anchor text. For example, a reference to 'rice flour' on the Unniyappam page should link directly to the Puttu recipe. Review and remove any unnecessary rel=nofollow attributes from internal links to allow full PageRank flow across the site.

6.9 URL Structure & Custom Domain

Update the WordPress permalink setting from date-based to 'Post name' format. This will produce cleaner, shorter, and more evergreen URLs such as /unniyappam-kerala-sweet-fritters/ in place of /2025/05/23/unniyappam/. Additionally, migrate from the wordpress.com subdomain to a dedicated custom domain to improve brand authority, technical control, and long-term SEO scalability.

6.10 Content Expansion & Quality

Develop an editorial calendar targeting consistent publication of new Kerala recipe posts. Expand the 12 identified thin-content pages to a minimum of 300–800 words each, incorporating ingredient context, cultural notes, cooking tips, and FAQs. Add FAQ sections to existing recipe pages to enable FAQPage schema implementation and improve topical depth.

7. Priority Action Plan

Phase	Task	Start Date	Duration	Priority	Expected Outcome
On-Page SEO	Rewrite all title tags and meta descriptions	10 May 2026	5 days	High	Improved CTR; stronger keyword signals in SERPs
On-Page SEO	Add alt text to all 41 images	15 May 2026	3 days	High	Improved image SEO, accessibility, and relevance
On-Page SEO	Fix H1 structure — one H1 per page	15 May 2026	2 days	High	Clear content hierarchy; stronger relevance signal
Technical SEO	Install SEO plugin (Yoast SEO / Rank Math)	11 May 2026	2 days	High	Full metadata, sitemap, and schema control
Technical SEO	Compress images; convert to WebP/AVIF	12 May 2026	5 days	High	Faster load times; major LCP improvement
Technical SEO	Fix above-fold lazy loading issue	12 May 2026	1 day	High	Directly reduces mobile LCP
Technical SEO	Implement JSON-LD Recipe schema on all recipe pages	14 May 2026	3 days	High	Eligibility for rich results and recipe carousels
Technical SEO	Set up Google Analytics 4 and Google Tag Manager	11 May 2026	2 days	High	Traffic and behaviour data available for analysis
Technical SEO	Enable browser caching; defer non-critical JS/CSS	16 May 2026	2 days	Medium	Improved repeat-visit performance; faster rendering
Site Structure	Update permalinks to Post Name format (remove dates)	18 May 2026	1 day	Medium	Cleaner, evergreen URLs
Site Structure	Migrate to a custom domain	19 May 2026	2 days	Medium	Improved brand authority and SEO control
Content & Links	Add keyword-rich internal links across all recipe pages	20 May 2026	7 days	High	Better crawl flow and authority distribution
Content & Links	Expand thin content pages (12 identified); add FAQ sections	20 May 2026	14 days	High	Improved content depth; FAQ schema eligibility
Content & Links	Publish 5+ new recipe posts	20 May 2026	30 days	High	Expanded keyword footprint; stronger topical authority
Monitoring	Review PageSpeed Insights and Search Console	20 Jun 2026	Ongoing	High	Validate improvements; identify next optimisation cycle

8. Expected Outcomes

Successful implementation of the recommendations in this report is expected to produce the following measurable improvements:

- Enhanced crawlability, with Googlebot discovering and indexing new content more frequently as publishing frequency increases.
- A significant increase in indexed pages as content depth is improved and thin pages are expanded.
- Materially improved mobile and desktop page speed scores, with a target mobile LCP of 2.5 seconds or below following image optimisation and lazy loading fixes.
- Eligibility for Recipe rich results in Google Search, increasing SERP visibility, click-through rates, and brand recognition.
- Higher click-through rates driven by longer, more informative title tags and meta descriptions.
- Improved keyword relevance through the addition of alt text to all images and keyword-rich internal anchor text.
- Stronger internal authority distribution across the site, supporting the ranking potential of all recipe pages.
- Access to full traffic and user behaviour data via Google Analytics 4, enabling data-driven content and SEO decisions.
- Improved brand credibility and technical flexibility following migration to a custom domain.

Monitoring Recommendation

Progress should be tracked monthly via Google Search Console and Google Analytics. Key metrics to monitor: indexed page count, organic impressions and clicks, Core Web Vitals scores, and SERP feature appearances.

9. Conclusion

Athy's Kitchen Diary holds genuine and significant potential as a niche content authority for Kerala home cooking. The existing recipe posts demonstrate clear cultural authenticity and culinary depth — qualities that Google increasingly rewards through its emphasis on expertise, experience, and trustworthiness.

The most critical issues identified in this audit are: 41 images missing alt text, title tags and meta descriptions that are significantly under-optimised, a mobile LCP of 21.2 seconds driven by uncompressed images and above-fold lazy loading, and the complete absence of structured data across all recipe pages. Each of these issues is fixable within a short timeframe and should be treated as immediate priorities.

The action plan presented in this report is structured to deliver meaningful quick wins in the near term — metadata, alt text, image compression, and above-fold lazy loading fixes — while simultaneously building toward more substantial, compounding gains through content expansion, structured data implementation, and domain migration.

With consistent execution over the coming 60 to 90 days, Athy's Kitchen Diary should see clear, measurable improvements across all core SEO metrics: indexed page count, crawl frequency, organic impressions and clicks, page speed scores, and SERP feature eligibility. These improvements will collectively strengthen the site's position in search results and contribute to sustainable long-term organic growth.

Report prepared by Athiramol PS | April 2026 | Confidential

10. Appendix — Preliminary Questions

#	Thing to check	Method	Response	Notes	Recommendations
1	Was this website recently migrated from another platform, server, or domain?	Ask client	No		No action required. Continue monitoring for any unexpected fluctuations in performance.
2	What was the reason for the migration?	Ask client	N/A		No action required.
3	If a migration was performed, was there a drop in rankings, conversions or organic traffic?	Ask client	N/A		No action required.
4	When did the migration take place?	Ask client	N/A		No action required.
5	Are there crawls of the website pre-migration?	Ask client	N/A		No action required.
6	Do you or the client have admin access to the WordPress dashboard?	Ask client	Yes		Ensure proper role-based access control and maintain backups before implementing SEO changes.
7	Do you or the client have admin access to DNS settings?	Ask client	No		Request DNS access or coordinate with the hosting provider for domain-level changes.
8	Is Google Tag Manager being used?	Manual check	No		Implement Google Tag Manager to manage tracking scripts efficiently without code changes.
9	Do you or the client have access privileges to Google Tag Manager?	Ask client	No	Can't implement in WP free version	Upgrade WordPress plan or use alternative plugin-based tracking solutions.
10	Do you or the client have access privileges to Google Search Console?	Ask client	Yes		Regularly monitor performance reports and indexing issues for SEO improvements.
11	Do you or the client have access privileges to Google Analytics?	Ask client	No		Request access or set up a new property to enable performance tracking.
12	Is Google Search Console connected?	GSC	Yes		Ensure all property versions (HTTP/HTTPS, WWW/non-WWW) are verified.
13	Does Google Search Console have data?	GSC	Yes		Use query and page-level data to identify optimization opportunities.
14	Is Google Analytics connected?	GA	No		Set up Google Analytics (GA4) for traffic and user behavior tracking.
15	Does Universal Google Analytics have data?	GA	N/A		No action required (UA deprecated).
16	Is there more than one UA profile?	Manual check	No		No action required.
17	Has Google Analytics 4 been set up?	GA	No		Set up Google Analytics 4 to ensure future-proof tracking.

#	Thing to check	Method	Response	Notes	Recommendations
18	Does Google Analytics 4 have data?	GA	No		After setup, validate data collection and configure key events (conversions).
19	Are AMP pages being tracked in a separate Google Analytics property?	GA	No		If AMP is implemented in future, configure separate tracking.

10. Appendix — Crawling

#	Thing to check	Method	Response	Notes	Recommendations
1	Is there a robots.txt file?	Manual check	Yes	Standard WordPress robots.txt	No immediate action required. Periodically review robots.txt to ensure no important content is accidentally blocked.
2	Are crawlers being blocked in the robots.txt file?	GSC	No		No action required. Maintain full crawl access for search engines.
3	Are paginated URLs being blocked in robots.txt?	Manual check	No		No action required.
4	Are JavaScript files being blocked in robots.txt?	Screaming Frog	No		No action required. Allowing JS ensures proper rendering and indexing.
5	Does the robots.txt file disallow parameterised URLs?	Manual check	No		Monitor parameter URLs in future. If duplicates arise, handle via canonical tags.
6	Are there any host status problems reported in Search Console crawl stats?	GSC	No	Host had no problems in last 90 days	No action required. Continue monitoring server performance in crawl stats.
7	Are there crawl requests being made as reported in Search Console crawl stats?	GSC	No	Low/limited crawl activity	Increase crawl demand by publishing new content regularly and improving internal linking.
8	Are there crawl requests being made for 'refresh' purposes in Search Console crawl stats?	GSC	Yes	Refresh 98%	Update old blog posts (content freshness) and add internal links to keep them relevant.
9	Are there crawl requests being made for 'discovery' purposes in Search Console crawl stats?	GSC	Yes	Discovery 2%	Publish new posts consistently and link them from homepage and category pages.
10	According to Search Console crawl stats, have HTML files been crawled in the last 72-hours?	GSC	Yes		No action required. Indicates Googlebot is active on the site.
11	Does the website have a sitemap?	Manual check	Yes		No action required. Ensure sitemap updates dynamically when new posts are added.
12	Is the sitemap XML or HTML?	Manual check	XML		No action required. XML sitemap is best practice for search engines.
13	Is the sitemap index URL(s) referenced in the robots.txt file?	Manual check	Yes		No action required. Helps search engines easily discover sitemap.
14	How many URLs are in the sitemap?	Screaming Frog	55		Continue scaling content to increase sitemap size and organic reach.
15	Are there more than 1000 URLs in a sitemap?	Screaming Frog	No		No action required.

#	Thing to check	Method	Response Notes	Recommendations
16	Are non-indexable URLs in the sitemap?	Screaming Frog	No	No action required. Maintain clean sitemap with only indexable URLs.
17	Are there URLs that are blocked in robots.txt that are found in the sitemap?	Screaming Frog	No	No action required. Maintain this alignment to avoid crawl conflicts.
18	Have sitemaps been submitted to Google Search Console?	GSC	Yes	Regularly monitor sitemap report in GSC to track indexing and errors.
19	Has Google Search Console processed the submitted sitemap(s)?	GSC	Yes	No action required. Ensure newly added URLs are indexed without delay.
20	Can internal search URLs be crawled?	Manual check	No	No action required. Best practice to keep internal search pages non-crawlable.
21	Are there any internal links not wrapped by an <a> tag?	Manual check	No	No action required. Proper HTML linking ensures crawlability and link equity flow.

10. Appendix — Rendering

#	Thing to check	Method	Response	Notes	Recommendations
1	Is there a trend of increasing 'Submitted URL seems to be a soft 404' in Search Console?	GSC	No		No action required. Continue monitoring index coverage in Google Search Console.
2	What theme is being used?	Manual	TwentyTwentyOne		Ensure the theme is regularly updated to avoid performance and security issues.
3	Are there known issues with this theme?	N/A	No		No action required. Periodically review theme performance and compatibility.
4	Does the website use a pagebuilder?	Manual	No		No action required. Reduces DOM complexity and improves performance.
5	Does the pagebuilder have known issues?	N/A	No		No action required.
6	Is lazy loading applied to above-the-fold images?	N/A	Yes		Review lazy loading implementation — above-the-fold images should ideally not be lazy loaded, as this can delay LCP.
7	Does the primary navigation menu load when JavaScript is disabled?	Manual	Yes	Works fine	No action required. This ensures accessibility and crawlability.
8	Is all the body content visible when JavaScript is disabled?	Manual	Yes		No action required. This is a strong positive signal for search engine rendering.

10. Appendix — Indexing

#	Thing to check	Method	Response	Notes	Recommendations
1	Does the website rank in the top 2 positions when searching for the brand name?	Manual	Yes	First place	No action required. Maintain brand SERP dominance through consistent branding and content updates.
2	Does http redirect to https?	Manual	Yes	Redirects correctly	No action required. Ensure SSL certificate remains valid and up to date.
3	Is the site www or non-www?	Manual	Non-www		No action required. Maintain consistency across all internal links and canonical tags.
4	If www by default, does non-www redirect to www?	Manual	N/A		No action required.
5	If non-www by default, does www redirect to non-www?	Manual	Yes		No action required. Proper canonicalisation is in place.
6	Do URLs end with a trailing slash or non-trailing slash?	Manual	Yes	/recipes/	No action required. Maintain consistent URL structure.
7	If URLs have a trailing slash by default, do URLs without trailing slash redirect to trailing slash?	Manual	Yes		No action required. Prevents duplicate content issues.
8	If URLs do not have a trailing slash by default, do URLs with a trailing slash redirect to non-trailing slash?	Manual	N/A		No action required.
9	Are there orphaned URLs in the sitemap?	Screaming Frog	No		No action required. Maintain strong internal linking structure.
10	Are there 301 URLs in the sitemap?	Screaming Frog	No		No action required. Sitemap is clean.
11	Are there 404 URLs in the sitemap?	Screaming Frog	No		No action required.
12	How are sitemaps generated on the website?	Manual	Dynamically		No action required. Ensure automatic updates continue.
13	Do any of the sitemaps in Google Search Console show errors?	GSC	No		Continue monitoring in Google Search Console.
14	Are there errors reported in Search Console index coverage?	GSC	Yes	2 pages crawled but not indexed: /recipes/ and mambazha-pulisserie post	Inspect affected URLs in Google Search Console and request indexing after resolving potential content or crawl issues.
15	Are these errors expected?	N/A	No		Investigate root cause (content quality, internal links, crawl priority) and resolve promptly.

#	Thing to check	Method	Response		Notes	Recommendations
16	Are there URLs marked as 'Submitted URL blocked by robots.txt' in Search Console?	GSC	No			No action required.
17	Are there valid URLs reported in Search Console index coverage?	GSC	Yes			No action required.
18	Are there an increasing number of URLs reported as 'Indexed not submitted in sitemap'?	GSC	No			No action required.
19	Are there excluded URLs reported in Search Console index coverage?	GSC	No			No action required.
20	Is there a trend of increasing URLs reported as 'Crawled - currently not indexed'?	GSC	No			Continue monitoring for early detection of indexing issues.
21	Is there a trend of increasing URLs reported as 'Discovered - currently not indexed'?	GSC	No			No action required.
22	Is there a trend of increasing URLs reported as 'Excluded by noindex tag'?	GSC	No			No action required.
23	Is there a trend of increasing URLs reported as 'Duplicate without user-selected canonical'?	GSC	No			No action required.
24	Is there a trend of increasing URLs reported as 'Duplicate, Google chose different canonical than user'?	GSC	No			No action required.
25	In Search Console Search Performance, are clicks trending up, down or staying steady in the last 16-months?	GSC	Steady	Stable		Improve click-through rate by optimising titles and meta descriptions.
26	In Search Console Search Performance, are impressions trending up, down or staying steady in the last 16-months?	GSC	Trending up	Growth observed		Continue publishing content to sustain the upward trend.
27	Are there non-indexable URLs?	Screaming Frog	Yes		Only the 301 redirects. Privacy page was noindex	Ensure intentional use of noindex and avoid accidental exclusion of important pages.
28	Should these URLs be set as noindex?	GSC	Yes			No action required.
29	Are there 301/302 redirections in place?	GSC	N/A			Monitor redirects during future updates or migrations.
30	Are these redirections correct?	N/A	N/A			No action required.

#	Thing to check	Method	Response	Notes	Recommendations
31	Are there internal links pointing to 404 or 301 URLs?	Screaming Frog	No		No action required. Maintain clean linking.
32	Are there redirect chains?	Semrush	No		No action required.
33	Do URLs have canonicals set?	Manual	Yes		No action required.
34	Are the canonical tags correct?	Screaming Frog	Yes		No action required.
35	Are internal search URLs indexable?	Screaming Frog	No	Correct setup	No action required. Prevents thin/duplicate content issues.
36	Does the website have internal links pointing towards URLs generated by internal search?	Screaming Frog	No		No action required.
37	How many indexable URLs does the website have?	Screaming Frog	25		Increase indexable pages through content expansion strategy.
38	How many URLs are indexed on Google?	SF + GSC	5	Low indexation	Improve internal linking, content quality, and submit URLs via Google Search Console.
39	How many URLs are not indexed on Google?	SF + GSC	2		Investigate reasons and request indexing after fixes.
40	How many low content pages exist?	Screaming Frog	12	Thin content	Expand content on these pages (target 300-800+ words), add internal links, and improve relevance.
41	Does a site: operator search show paginated URLs in the search results?	Manual	N/A		No action required.
42	Are all paginated series indexable?	SF	N/A		No action required.
43	Are paginated URLs being canonicalized to a 'view all' page?	SF	N/A		No action required.
44	Are paginated URLs being canonicalized to a root page?	SF	N/A		No action required.
45	Do internal links to paginated pages use 'rel=nofollow' attribute?	SF	N/A		No action required.
46	Do pages that don't exist return a 404 or 200 HTTP status code response?	Manual	Yes		No action required. Correct implementation.
47	Have URLs been submitted to Search Console removal tool?	GSC	No		Use removal tool only if urgent deindexing is required.
48	Does faceted navigation create indexable URLs?	Manual	No		No action required. Prevents crawl waste.
49	Does a site: operator search show parametrised URLs in the search results?	Manual	No		No action required.

#	Thing to check	Method	Response	Notes	Recommendations
50	Do all pages have a h1?	Screaming Frog	No		Ensure every indexable page has a unique H1 for SEO clarity.
51	Are there empty h1 tags?	Screaming Frog	No		No action required.
52	Is there more than one h1 per URL?	Screaming Frog	No		No action required.
53	Are title links the same as h1?	Screaming Frog	No		No action required. Variation is acceptable.
54	Can title links have different text as the h1?	Manual	Yes		No action required.
55	Are WordPress tags being used?	WordPress Admin	Yes		Review tag usage to avoid thin or duplicate archive pages.
56	Are WordPress tags indexable?	WordPress Admin	Yes		Consider noindexing low-value tag pages to improve crawl efficiency.
57	Do WordPress tags have canonical URLs?	Screaming Frog	Yes		No action required.
58	Are WordPress categories being used?	Manual	Yes		No action required.
59	Are WordPress categories pages indexable?	WordPress Admin	Yes		Optimise category pages with content to improve rankings.
60	Do WordPress categories have canonical URLs?	SF	Yes		No action required.
61	Are URLs with parametrised URLs indexable?	WordPress Admin	No		No action required.
62	Does the business have permanently discontinued products?	N/A	N/A		No action required.
63	Can these URLs be reused or repurposed?	Ask client	N/A		No action required.
64	Do permanently discontinued product URLs return a 301, 404 or 410 HTTP status code?	Screaming Frog	N/A		No action required.
65	Have permanently discontinued product URLs been marked as noindex?	Screaming Frog	N/A		No action required.
66	If a 301 redirect exists, do they point to a relevant or irrelevant URL?	Screaming Frog	N/A		Ensure any future redirects point to highly relevant pages to preserve SEO value.

10. Appendix — Ranking

#	Thing to check	Method	Response	Notes	Recommendations
1	Do important service URLs have descriptive anchor text internal links pointing to them from multiple URLs?	Screaming Frog	No	Only 'Athys Kitchen Diary', 'Home'	Add keyword-rich anchor text (e.g., recipe names, cuisine types) in internal links to improve topical relevance and rankings.
2	Do important product category pages have descriptive anchor text internal links pointing to them from multiple URLs?	Screaming Frog	N/A	Not ecommerce	No action required.
3	Do primary keyword URLs have descriptive anchor text internal links pointing to them from multiple URLs?	Screaming Frog	Yes		Expand internal linking to ensure all important pages receive consistent keyword-rich links.
4	Do important service URLs have a crawl depth greater than 2 clicks from the homepage?	Manual	Yes		Reduce crawl depth by linking key pages directly from homepage or main navigation.
5	How many pages are not mobile-friendly?	Screaming Frog + GSC	1	Slow loading	Optimise page speed and mobile usability using Google PageSpeed Insights.
6	Do any 404 URLs have referring domains linking to them?	Ahrefs	No		No action required.
7	Have these 404 URLs been 301 redirected?	Screaming Frog	N/A		No action required.
8	Do the pages with the most traffic link to other important URLs?	Screaming Frog	No	Low traffic overall	Add internal links from top-performing pages to key pages to distribute link equity.
9	Do internal links have descriptive anchor text that conveys what the target URL is about?	Screaming Frog	No		Replace generic anchors (e.g., 'click here') with descriptive, keyword-focused anchor text.
10	Do internal links use a variety of keyword-rich anchor text?	Screaming Frog	No		Introduce variation in anchor text to avoid over-optimisation and improve semantic relevance.
11	Do any internal links have rel=nofollow attribute?	Screaming Frog	Yes		Review and remove unnecessary nofollow attributes from internal links to allow proper PageRank flow.
12	Are years, months and dates used in subfolders?	Screaming Frog	Yes		Consider removing dates from URLs for evergreen content to prevent perceived content aging.
13	Are years, months and dates used in URL slugs?	Screaming Frog	Yes		Avoid date-based URLs for long-term SEO; use clean, keyword-focused slugs instead.
14	Do ranking URLs have rich results?	Manual	N/A	No enhancements	Implement structured data (e.g., Recipe schema) to enable rich results in SERPs.
15	Do FAQPage rich results have internal links?	Rich Results Test	N/A	No FAQ sections	Add FAQ sections with internal links to improve SEO and user engagement.

#	Thing to check	Method	Response	Notes	Recommendations
16	Can FAQPage or HowTo rich results be added to existing ranking URLs?	N/A	Yes	Opportunity exists	Implement structured data (FAQPage, HowTo, Recipe schema) to enhance visibility and CTR.

10. Appendix — Other Technical SEO and UX

#	Thing to check	Method	Response	Notes	Recommendations
1	Does the site load via https protocol?	Manual	Yes		No action required. Ensure SSL certificate is consistently renewed.
2	Is HSTS enabled?	Screaming Frog	Yes		No action required. This improves security and trust signals.
3	Does the website have a staging environment?	Ask client	No	No staging environment. Hosted on WordPress.com.	Consider using a local or alternative staging setup (if scaling in future) to safely test SEO changes before deployment.
4	Has the staging environment been indexed by Google?	GSC	No		No action required.
5	Is the staging environment indexable?	SEO Pro	No		No action required.
6	Are there internal links pointing to the staging environment?	Screaming Frog	No		No action required.
7	Does the staging environment have password protection?	Manual	N/A		No action required.
8	Are there plugins that have not been updated?	Manual	N/A	No plugins installed	No action required.
9	Is the active theme up-to-date?	Manual	Yes	Active Theme	Continue regular updates to maintain performance and security.
10	Is the version of WordPress up-to-date?	Manual	Yes		No action required.
11	Does running a crawl on the site cause browsing on the website to become significantly slower?	Manual	No	Score ~60/100	Improve performance score by optimising images, caching, and scripts.
12	Does running a crawl on the site cause 5XX status codes?	SEO Pro	No		No action required.
13	Is there an SEO plugin installed?	Manual	No		Install an SEO plugin such as Yoast SEO or Rank Math to manage metadata, schema, and technical SEO efficiently.
14	What SEO plugin is being used?	Manual	None	No Plugins Installed	Implement an SEO plugin to gain control over titles, meta descriptions, and indexing settings.
15	How many plugins are installed?	Manual	0		No action required, but essential plugins (SEO, caching, image optimisation) should be added.
16	Are there images over 750KB in filesize?	Screaming Frog	Yes	Up to 2.3MB	Compress and optimise images using tools like TinyPNG to improve page speed.
17	Are there images exceeding 1MB in filesize?	Screaming Frog	Yes		Resize and serve images in next-gen formats (e.g., WebP) to reduce load time and improve Core Web Vitals.

#	Thing to check	Method	Response	Notes	Recommendations
18	Do internal links use absolute URLs or relative URLs?	Screaming Frog	Absolute		No action required. Absolute URLs are acceptable, but ensure consistency across the site.

10. Appendix — URL Issues

#	Thing to check	Method	Notes	Recommendations
1	Are URLs friendly (short and easy to share)	Manual Browser Search	Short and clean, easy to remember, HTTPS secure, brand name included	Consider upgrading from WordPress subdomain to a custom domain for stronger branding, credibility, and SEO performance.
2	Are URLs optimized (usage of target keywords)	Manual Browser Search	Contains main keywords, but long structure with date included (/2025/05/23/)	Remove unnecessary date-based URL structure to create shorter, cleaner, and keyword-focused URLs. Example: /meen-varuthathu-meen-porichathu/.

10. Appendix — Page Speed and Mobile Friendliness

#	Thing to check	Method	Notes	Recommendations
1	Google PageSpeed Insights (desktop) - home page	Google PageSpeed Insights	FCP: 1.0s LCP: 4.5s TBT: 0ms CLS: 0.168 Speed Index: 1.6s	Improve LCP by optimising above-the-fold images. Implement proper caching policies and minimise render-blocking resources. Address layout shifts to improve CLS score.
2	Google PageSpeed Insights (mobile) - home page	Google PageSpeed Insights	FCP: 5.1s LCP: 21.2s TBT: 10ms CLS: 0.032 Speed Index: 5.1s	Prioritise mobile optimisation by compressing and resizing images, using next-gen formats (WebP), and reducing large featured images. Improve server response time and enable caching to significantly reduce LCP.
3	Mobile Friendliness (Desktop)	Google PageSpeed Insights	Score: 85 — Good performance but not fully optimized.	Improve Core Web Vitals by optimizing LCP, reducing unused CSS, and compressing images to achieve a score above 90.
4	Mobile Friendliness (Mobile)	Google PageSpeed Insights	Score: 60 — Needs significant improvement. Slow load time impacting user experience and rankings.	Optimize mobile performance by compressing images (use WebP), reducing large hero images, enabling lazy loading for below-fold content, minimizing JavaScript, and improving server response time to target a score above 80.

Glossary of SEO Terms

A

Alt Text (Alternative Text)

The alt attribute of an `<img>` tag, describing the image content. Essential for accessibility and image search optimization.

Anchor Text

The clickable text of a hyperlink. Descriptive, keyword-rich anchor text tells search engines what the linked page is about. Avoid vague anchors like 'click here'.

B

Backlink

An external link from another site. Quality backlinks boost authority.

Bounce Rate

Percentage of visitors who leave after viewing one page. High bounce can indicate irrelevant content or slow UX.

C

Canonical Tag

An HTML tag specifying the 'master' URL when duplicates exist. Prevents duplicate content penalties.

Core Web Vitals

Google's key UX metrics: LCP (load speed target $\leq 2.5s$), INP (responsiveness), and CLS (visual stability target ≤ 0.1).

Crawlability

The ability of search engine bots to access and navigate your website. Robots.txt controls crawler access.

I

Indexing

The process of search engines adding pages to their database. Indexed pages can appear in search results.

Internal Linking

Links connecting pages within the same website. Distributes authority and helps crawlers discover content.

P

PageSpeed Score

A metric (0-100) from Google PageSpeed Insights. Reflects Core Web Vitals and other speed factors. Higher is better.

R

Redirect Chain

Multiple sequential redirects between the original URL and final destination. Slows load speed and dilutes link equity.

Rich Results

Enhanced search listings with images, ratings, cooking time etc., enabled by structured data. Recipe schema can unlock these.

Robots.txt

A text file at the site root giving instructions to crawlers about which URLs they may access.

S

Schema Markup / Structured Data

Code (usually JSON-LD) that marks up content so search engines can display rich results. For recipes, use Schema.org's Recipe type.

SEO (Search Engine Optimization)

Practices to improve a website's visibility and ranking in search results. Includes on-page, off-page, and technical optimizations.

SERP

Search Engine Results Page — the page displayed by a search engine in response to a user's query.

Sitemap (XML)

A file listing all important URLs on a website, helping search engines discover and index content efficiently.

Glossary of SEO Terms (cont.)

H

H1 Tag

The main heading of a page. There should typically be only one <h1> per page. Descriptive H1s improve SEO and accessibility.

HSTS

HTTP Strict Transport Security — forces browsers to use HTTPS. Improves security and provides minor SEO benefit.

L

LCP (Largest Contentful Paint)

Time it takes to load the largest visible element (often hero image). Critical for perceived load time. Target: <=2.5s.

Lazy Loading

A technique where images load only when they come into view. Should not be applied to above-the-fold images as it delays LCP.

M

Meta Description

A brief summary (120-160 characters) of a page's content. Helps searchers decide to click. Should be unique and relevant per page.

Mobile-First Indexing

Google predominantly uses the mobile version of content for indexing. Mobile-friendly design and speed are thus crucial.

T

Title Tag

The <title> element in a page's HTML. Appears as the clickable headline in search results. Keep under ~60 characters.

U

URL Canonicalisation

Ensuring one preferred URL per page. Prevents duplicate content issues.

W

WebP / AVIF

Modern image formats that produce smaller file sizes than JPEG or PNG at equivalent quality. Converting images to these formats significantly reduces LCP.



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